



Care-based relationship management during remote work in a crisis: Empathy, purpose, and diversity climate as emergent employee-organization relational maintenance strategies

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ABSTRACT

This study examined the relational maintenance strategies employed by organizations to maintain relationships with employees over remote/hybrid work in a crisis. Thirteen in-depth elite interviews with heads of communication and human resources from organizations on various top employer lists were conducted. The seven main themes generated from the interviews were clustered into two sets of strategies. The first set consisted of strategies that are widely accepted in current relationship management theorizing in public relations, specifically access, assurances, positivity, and openness. The second set included three emergent strategies, namely, empathy, purpose, and diversity climate. Together, these strategies reflected the lived experiences of employers as they grappled with maintaining relationships with employees remotely while navigating uncertain and ambiguous environments. The findings of this study strengthen theorizing on care-based employee relationship management in the context of remote/hybrid work during crises.

1. Introduction

The Novel Coronavirus pandemic (hereafter referred to as the COVID-19 pandemic) abruptly disrupted face-to-face work in 2020–2022 with organizations adopting remote/hybrid work models amidst much anxiety and uncertainty. In these contexts of tumultuous, unplanned change, organizations had to continue to build and maintain employee-organization relationships (EOR). Although the constructs of organization-public relationships (OPR) (Broom, Casey, & Ritchey, 1997; Grunig, 1993; Hon & Grunig, 1999; Ledingham & Bruning, 1998) and EOR have been theorized robustly within public relations scholarship (Lee, 2022; Kim & Rhee, 2011; Men & Stacks, 2014), little research has explored employee relationship management in the context of remote/hybrid work, which could imply not just physical but also social and affective distancing between organizations and employees (Dhanesh & Duthler, 2021; Einwiller, Ruppel, & Stranzl, 2021; Ruppel, Stranzl, & Einwiller, 2022). This is important to study as organizations, based on increasing employee demands, are considering continuing with remote, flexible work arrangements even beyond the times of the pandemic, and it is imperative to understand how organizations can continue to foster strong relationships with employees even in remote contexts of work.

We have adopted Men and Stacks' (2014) definition of EOR as "the degree to which an organization and its employees trust one another, agree on who has the rightful power to influence, experience satisfaction with each other, and commit oneself to the other" (p. 307) as it mirrors the relational outcomes of trust, control mutuality, satisfaction, and commitment in one of the most widely cited definitions of OPR by Hon and Grunig (1999). These relational outcomes can be fostered through effective relationship maintenance strategies such as assurances, access, openness, positivity, networking, and sharing of tasks (Hon & Grunig, 1999). In addition, variables such as participatory, supportive, and emotional organizational cultures (Grunig, Grunig, & Dozier, 2002; Men & Jiang, 2016; Men & Robinson, 2018), symmetrical internal communication (Lee, 2022; Kim & Rhee, 2011), transparent internal communication (Li, Sun, Tao, & Lee, 2021), and organizational justice (Lee, 2021) have also been found to foster effective relationships with publics such as employees. High quality EORs also exhibit interactions grounded on principles such as dialogue and reciprocity (Baxter, 2011). While acknowledging no ideal relationships exist, a good relationship enables relational parties to exercise mutual influence on each other through both two-way communication and listening (Coombs & Holladay, 2007) which produces equitable outcomes for both parties (Brown, 2010). Seen through the lens of care ethics, a good relationship is one that is

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continually built through ethical values and principles of caring (Dong & Morehouse, 2022). The likely outcome of such a relationship is parties seeking closeness/connection instead of distance/disconnection (Waymer, 2013).

However, when organizations adopt remote/hybrid modes of work, additional stressors are placed on building and sustaining relationships with employees. Not only were organizations and employees caught in a global health crisis that unleashed much panic and anxiety, but they also had to deal with new ways of working that could impact employees through reduced social support (Dhanesh & Duthler, 2021; Einwiller et al., 2021), exhaustion and burnout (Fonner & Roloff, 2010), and less social interaction, connection, and collaboration among employees (Goman, 2017). Such turbulent contexts of unplanned change call for a re-examination of effective relational maintenance strategies.

Emerging research on the impact of remote/hybrid work on employee engagement have shown that internal crisis communication content, two-way communication as well as relational and informational communication predicted employee engagement (Dhanesh & Duthler, 2021; Einwiller et al., 2021). Research has also stressed the role of information resources, transparent internal communication (Blau, 1964; Coombs, 1999; Coombs & Holladay, 2008; Coombs, 2015; Heide & Simonsson, 2020; Li et al., 2021) and ethics of care (Branicki, 2020; Fraustino & Kennedy, 2018; Tao & Kim, 2017) in reassuring publics of organizations' commitment and genuine concern. As such, scholars have suggested a wide array of communication strategies and tactics at the disposal of organizations when crises arise. However, an in-depth understanding of factors that impact relationship management with employees in remote/hybrid contexts during a crisis is missing.

Accordingly, situated within relationship management theorizing in public relations (Hon & Grunig, 1999) and a care ethics framework (Dong & Morehouse, 2022; Noddings, 2013; 2015; Tronto, 1993), this study aimed to examine employee-organization relationship maintenance strategies during remote/hybrid work contexts during a crisis. Theoretically, the findings of this study will add to emergent empirical insights into relationship management in the context of remote work in turbulent contexts of unplanned change, specifically care-based strategies to maintain EORs. Practically, findings can guide internal communication, employee relations and public relations practitioners to effectively maintain relationships with employees in new modes of working.

2. Literature review

2.1. Relationship management theorizing in public relations

Managing relationships between organizations and their publics has been widely studied since Ferguson (1984) proposed a shift towards relationship building as the primary function of public relations. The Excellence Study (Grunig, Grunig, and Ehling, 1992) emphasized the importance of building quality, long-term relationships with strategic constituencies to enhance effectiveness. Grunig's (1992) two-way symmetrical model highlighted the reciprocal exchanges between organizations and their key publics, resulting in mutually beneficial outcomes for both interacting parties. Further, Broom et al. (1997) defined relationships as "the exchange or transfer of information, energy, or resources" (p. 94), delineating their model with antecedents, the concept relationships, and consequences. Grunig and Huang (2000) responded to Broom's model by proposing OPR can be defined and measured through situational antecedents, maintenance strategies, and relationship outcomes. In this study, we primarily operationalize OPR as the relationship organizations have with publics in which both entities can affect each other (i.e., by means of situational antecedents) and the relationship is managed through maintenance strategies which results in relationship outcomes (Grunig & Huang, 2000).

Subsequent studies on relationship management focused on building and maintaining quality OPRs, and facilitating interactions that benefit

both publics and organizations (Grunig & Huang, 2000; Ledingham, 2003). One of the foci in relationship management theory was the assumption that OPRs should be cultivated for the sake of mutual benefits (Cheng, 2018). Proponents followed Grunig's (1992) two-way symmetrical model that stressed listening to publics and seeking win-win situations that satisfy the interests of both relational parties.

Yet, the complexity and dynamic nature of OPRs was only explored in later studies. Dougall (2006) found that organizations often displayed self-seeking behaviors and avoided symmetrical communication during the enactment of OPRs. Scholars like Ki and Shin (2006), Cheng (2018) as well as Seltzer and Lee (2018) recognized that relationships and views of relational parties are fluid and influenced by situational factors. Seltzer and Lee (2018) proposed a conceptual model of OPRs, proposing distal and proximal antecedents. Distal antecedents are enduring factors that influence perceptions of organizations, while proximal antecedents are "situational ... behaviors and interactions that precede and influence perceptions of OPRs" (Seltzer & Lee, 2018, p. 235). Their findings suggest that risk reduction, social/cultural expectations as well as "perceived issue and value congruence with the organization" were primary reasons for entering OPRs (Seltzer & Lee, 2018, p. 230). Browning, Lee, Park, Kim, and Collins (2020) expanded on this idea by conceptualizing organizational advocacy as a relational communication strategy. They found that organizations strengthen OPRs by expressing their positions on controversial issues, demonstrating a "shared commitment" with strategic publics (Browning et al., 2020, p. 1026).

2.2. Care ethics in the context of relationship management

More recently the established OPR paradigm has been criticized by Dong and Morehouse (2022) for its limitations in turbulent contexts, such as government-public relationships fraught with power imbalances. They propose adopting ethics of care or care ethics as a suitable alternative orientation. Ethics of care emphasizes reciprocity, humanity, genuineness and the protection of diversity and vulnerability in interactions (Dong & Morehouse, 2022). This theory is particularly applicable in unequal relationships, such as those between social workers and clients, parents and children, teachers and students, and doctors and patients (Engster, 2020). Adopting an ethics of care approach offers guidelines for how "unequal interactions" should be performed to promote moral relationships between individuals "despite disparities in power and vulnerability" (Engster, 2020, p. 628).

By adopting care ethics, organizations can manage unequal relationships, such as those between organizations and employees, by prioritizing relationship development rather than solely focusing on organizational goals (Dong & Morehouse, 2022). According to Tronto (1993), all relational parties can benefit from a care-based orientation to forming relationships.

Care ethics consists of four elements: caring about, taking care of, care-giving, and care receiving (Tronto, 1993). These elements give rise to four virtues or ethical dimensions, namely attentiveness, responsibility, competence, and responsiveness (Tronto, 1993). Attentiveness involves recognizing the need to care and being "other directed" (Tronto, 1993, p. 128). This takes the form of paying attention and recognizing another's needs, having conversations with them about it, and ascertaining their perceptions about how their needs could be addressed. Responsibility entails assuming care when needs arise, not as a mere obligation but from a moral position of taking care. Competence refers to performing caring work competently, which includes providing adequate resources. Responsiveness focuses on the care-receiver's responses to the care. It involves balancing the needs of caregivers and care-receivers while understanding their self-defined needs. This includes actively listening, acknowledging requests, and accommodating feedback.

This approach is particularly applicable to relationship management because it emphasizes moral behavior, relational parties' interdependence, recognition of vulnerability and inequality as well as the impact

of situational factors on relationships (Noddings, 2013; Robinson, 1997). First, having entered into a relationship, moral behavior (i.e., behaviors aimed at mutual benefit and welfare) is exhibited through complex reciprocal actions between the one-caring (caregiver) and the cared-for (care receiver) (Noddings, 2013). Relational parties are cognizant of the asymmetrical nature of the relationship because the cared-for relies on the one-caring, exposing inherent vulnerability and inequality. As situations and relationships evolve, and relational parties' needs change, the intensity of caring varies accordingly. For example, care-giving needs may increase during times of crises.

In a later study, Noddings (2015) explored the applicability of care ethics to organizational contexts. She noted that while organizations can fulfil certain needs, "they cannot care in the sense required by care ethics" (Noddings, 2015, p. 72). Organizations can, however, provide frameworks and conditions that support caring relationships.

Care ethics offers valuable guidance for managing OPRs and EORs characterized by power imbalances and asymmetry, expanding on established relationship maintenance strategies. The next section will further elaborate on both established strategies and additional strategies within the care ethics framework.

2.3. Relationship maintenance strategies

Grunig and Huang (2000) proposed relationship maintenance strategies as antecedents of good quality relationships. These strategies include access, positivity, openness, assurances, networking, and sharing of tasks (Grunig & Huang, 2000; Hon & Grunig, 1999). Granting access allows organizations to establish a relationship with their publics, while positive interactions contribute to stronger relations. Openness is achieved through transparent disclosures by both parties. Assurances demonstrate the commitment of both parties to address concerns and build trust. Networking occurs when organizations and publics build a group of similar networks. Additionally, relationships are maintained through joint problem-solving efforts (Grunig & Huang, 2000; Hon & Grunig, 1999). Implementing these strategies, leads to quality relationship outcomes, namely trust, satisfaction, commitment, and control mutuality (Grunig & Huang, 2000). Trust refers to the confidence in one another and each party's willingness to open themselves to the other party. Satisfaction is the extent to which both parties feel favorably toward each other. Commitment is the extent to which parties believe the relationship is worth investing in. Finally, control mutuality is the ability of both parties to influence one another.

Dong and Morehouse's (2022) care-based relationship cultivation model builds on and extends established relationship cultivation models. Their model proposes that openness and access along with five additional care-based strategies (i.e., empathy, listening, flexibility, prioritizing decision quality competency of publics, and humanization) can result in the ethical building of OPRs. While Dong and Morehouse's (2022) model is proposed in the context of government-public relationships, the model could be applicable to EORs as well especially during turbulent times when employees are working remotely during a crisis.

Viewed through the lens of care ethics, a quality relationship can be cultivated through people-centered strategies that focus on relationship building instead of narrowly focusing on organizational outcomes. The relational strategies proposed in the care-based relationship cultivation model advocate a humanistic approach in which publics' general welfare is prioritized (Dong & Morehouse, 2022). Moreover, relationships are developed through various relational tactics such as attentiveness, responsibility, competence, and responsiveness (Tronto, 1993). Noddings (2013; 2015) proposed that paying attention to needs, listening to relational parties, being receptive to feedback, and exhibiting empathy are ways in which committed relationships can be built. Additional care ethics relationship cultivation strategies include the ethical treatment of all involved relational parties (Noddings, 2015); the creation of inclusive spaces where limits are respected (Noddings, 2013);

acknowledgment that conflict is inevitable in relationships (Davidson, 2016); and recognition of publics' diversity in terms of demographics, opinions, and their unique vulnerabilities (Dong & Morehouse, 2022). These actions result in sustained relationships that signal on-going commitment and trust (Noddings, 2013).

The care ethics framework extends the established relationship cultivation model (Grunig & Huang, 2000; Hon & Grunig, 1999) and focuses on dimensions of care that are used to build strong relationships. The care ethics framework recognizes that relationships are asymmetrical but that relational parties can, and should be, treated ethically to achieve equitable outcomes (Brown, 2010). It is through the ethical treatment of relational parties that relationships are not only maintained but strengthened.

One of the key publics organizations have to maintain relationships with is its employees, as employees are relationally "interconnected and free to form relationships in the course of addressing organizational goals" (Pompper, 2012, p. 101). EOR has received continued attention in public relations and the next section provides a brief definition along with strategies used to maintain EORs.

2.4. Employee-organization relationships (EOR) and its drivers

Organizations maintain close connections with employees as a relational party, and they consistently work towards fostering and sustaining EORs. EOR is defined as "the degree to which an organization and its employees trust one another, agree on who has the rightful power to influence, experience satisfaction with each other, and commit oneself to the other" (Men & Stacks, 2014, p. 307). Given the role of quality EORs in achieving organizational success as well as fostering internal reputation and employee engagement (Saks, 2006), public relations literature has focused on EOR drivers, including but not limited to transparent internal communication, supportive organizational cultures, and organizational justice (Kim & Rhee, 2011; Li et al. 2021; Men & Jiang, 2016; Men & Stacks, 2014).

Transparent communication's effectiveness in nurturing EORs has been widely demonstrated. For example, Li et al. (2021) found that transparent internal communication reduced employees' uncertainty and positively impacted the relational quality between employees and organizations during crises. Transparent internal communication, (i.e., "accountable, truthful, and substantial information") strengthened EORs during the pandemic (Li et al., 2021, p. 3).

Additionally, various strategies for EOR cultivation have been examined. For instance, participatory organizational cultures that engage employees through organizational listening and granting employees opportunities to participate in decision-making processes were found to cultivate EORs (Grunig et al., 2002; Kim & Rhee, 2011; Lee, 2022).

Relatedly, supportive organizational cultures wherein stability and rewards are emphasized were predictors of quality EORs (Men & Jiang, 2016). Men and Robinson's (2018) study showed the positive impact of emotional cultures (joy, love, fear, and sadness) on the quality of EORs. More recently, Lee (2021) proposed that organizational justice, as an internal relationship management strategy, serves as an antecedent to EOR. Her study revealed that when employees are exposed to unfair treatment and other forms of injustice at work, their perceptions of the relationship with the organization were impacted.

The COVID-19 pandemic resulted in unprecedented organizational change and shifting organizational identities (Ernst & Schleiter, 2021) which had an impact on how EORs were managed. Managing EORs during hybrid/remote modes of work, which imposes special challenges on maintaining EORs, is reviewed next.

2.5. Managing EORs during hybrid/remote work contexts in times of crises

In a crisis, employees often experience "peculiar emotional and

cognitive reactions, such as insecurity, stress, feelings of betrayal, fear, and anger" (Mazzei, Kim, & Dell'Oro, 2012, p. 33). Depending on the type of industry, the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic was severe for many employees. Adverse consequences included blurring of boundaries between work/home (Peters & Blomme, 2019), stringent health regulations at work, lower salaries due to reduced working hours and even job losses (Kniffin et al., 2020). Because organizations and employees usually have an invested relationship, various strategies based on social exchange theory have been suggested to support employees and maintain EORs during crises. Social exchange theory posits that relationships are based on reciprocity (Blau, 1964). Thus, in order to gain support from their employees, organizations must offer support to their employees. For example, during the pandemic organizations utilized internal crisis communication to provide both informational and emotional resources to employees who were, in turn, required to reciprocate by means of "expansive cognitive, emotional and physical support" (Einwiller et al., 2021, p. 234). At the onset of crises, informational resources include both instructional information and diverse platforms for discussion (Heide & Simonsson, 2020), while emotional resources include acknowledging concerns and illustrating compassion (Coombs, 1999; Coombs & Holladay, 2008), listening and responding to employees' concerns (Mazzei & Ravazzani, 2015) as well as thanking and expressing appreciation for employees' efforts (Dirani et al., 2020; Einwiller et al., 2021).

Similarly, Dhanesh and Duthler (2021) proposed a Remote Internal Crisis Communication (RICC) framework to examine the antecedents of employee engagement during remote work in a crisis. Their findings showed that internal crisis communication content (communicative resources) provided by organizations can assist employees in managing additional job-related demands placed on them during remote work.

Additionally, Dhanesh and Duthler (2021) found that two-way communication (i.e., communication that flows both to and from publics (Grunig & Hunt, 1984)), "made employees feel heard" (p. 307). During crises, organizations need to communicate information while utilizing listening strategies to receive input and feedback from employees (Dhanesh & Duthler, 2021). Two-way communication is, thus, essential since employees might feel disconnected from their organizations, have multiple information needs (information seeking and information sharing), and require organizations to listen to their concerns and anxieties (Makarius & Larson, 2017). Tools such as surveys, focus groups, and other online spaces where publics can voice their views are used to facilitate listening (Macnamara, 2016).

A related study by Li et al. (2021) explored the antecedents of EORs during remote/hybrid work and showed transparent internal communication can promote EORs especially during organizational change. Their study found that employing a transparent internal communication strategy not only encouraged employees' "problem-focused control coping" (Li et al., 2021, p. 1), but also reduced uncertainty.

Although not investigated from a remote/hybrid work context, organizational empathy plays a key role in times of crisis (Coombs, 2015). From a crisis communication perspective, highly empathic leaders such as CEOs are more likely to show compassion and concern to their employees during crises (Coombs, 2015; James & Wooten, 2005). Moreover, in public relations literature, empathy is regarded as a crucial element in building meaningful OPRs (Kent & Taylor, 2002). From this perspective, empathy is used by organizations to facilitate dialogue and foster relationships of trust with key publics such as employees (Kent & Taylor, 2002). Expressions of empathy such as showing compassion, reassuring publics of the organization's genuine concern, and giving adequate and timely informational updates to help publics cope with stressors associated with crises (Coombs, 2007), are essentially emotional resources. These resources form part of a primary crisis response strategy aimed at managing OPRs. Schoofs, Fannes, and Claeys (2022) suggested that "empathy is not an isolated element within crisis responses" (p. 8), but rather integral to understanding the needs, emotions, and concerns of affected publics.

From the aforementioned it is clear that various factors impact EORs. However, the antecedents of EORs within a remote/hybrid work context have not yet been fully explored. This study, therefore, aims to contribute to EOR theorizing by exploring the maintenance strategies organizations implemented during remote/hybrid work in the COVID-19 pandemic. Accordingly, the following research question was posited to guide the study:

RQ: What relational maintenance strategies did organizations employ to manage EORs during remote/hybrid work contexts in the COVID-19 pandemic?

3. Method

The researchers employed a qualitative approach and data was generated through elite, in-depth interviews with communications and human resources leaders from companies in best employer lists in 2021 and 2022. Elite interviews focus on understanding perspectives and behaviors of individuals who occupy senior management and board level positions within organizations (Harvey, 2011). Since elites prefer to articulate their views often clarifying their viewpoints, an open-ended, semi-structured approach was adopted. The method is well-suited to an exploratory study that aims to delve deeper into leaders' perceptions of EOR and how relationships were managed during the pandemic.

3.1. Sampling

Purposeful sampling was used to identify organizations that could provide researchers with rich data to answer the research questions. Since we were examining organizational strategies to manage relationships in contexts of uncertainties, we decided to target companies on best employer lists. It was reasoned that these top employers managed employee-organization relationships well despite the pandemic. The sampling frame included organizations in the *Forbes* 2021 World's Best Employers, *Fortune* 100 Best Companies to Work for 2021, and LinkedIn Top Companies 2021, 2022 lists with a presence in the Middle East and Africa region. Introductions via a key informant resulted in 33 organizations being contacted. Interviews were conducted until theoretical saturation was reached at 13 interviews across 10 organizations. Interviews were conducted in person or online from March to May 2022. All interviews were conducted in English and the average length of the interviews was approximately 45–60 min. All recordings were transcribed and the resulting transcripts and interview notes, which ran to over 160 typed pages, were used for thematic analysis.

3.2. Participant profile and interview guide

The participants from multinational organizations held titles such as Communications Leader, Communications Director, Senior Vice President of Communications, Human Resources Operations Leader, and Senior Vice President of Human Resources. Of the 13 participants, nine were communications leaders and four human resources leaders, with seven males and six females. The organizations represented diverse industries including pharmaceuticals, professional services, engineering, manufacturing and production, and information technology services. The interview guide consisted of open-ended questions that explored the management of EOR over remote and flexible work and the communicative strategies used to manage EOR. The interview guide included the following questions: How did you manage relationships with employees over remote work? What strategies did the organization adopt to maintain relationships with employees during remote work?

3.3. Data analysis

We conducted manual thematic analysis, a suitable method to generate themes within data (Braun & Clarke, 2006). The analysis aimed

to identify patterns that could be interpreted as relational maintenance strategies utilized to maintain EORs. We undertook iterative rounds of literal, interpretive, and reflexive readings of the data to generate codes and themes that could be identified across the body of data. In addition to the transcripts, we also reviewed our field notes and reflections, which helped to enhance the richness of the analysis. Strategies to produce codes included examining the data for repetitions, metaphors, and analogies because these strategies along with examining for in vivo codes and theory related codes are effective ways of producing themes (Mason, 1996). While coding, we wrote memos on comparisons or any thought that led us towards greater abstraction. Creating analytic memos that elaborated on how the codes related to one another enabled open and axial coding to occur parallelly (Strauss & Corbin, 1998). The codes concerning similar antecedents and communicative strategies were then arranged into larger groups. As the analysis generated new themes, we engaged in constant comparison with the data to refine and confirm the themes. The researchers met to discuss the code refining process and identified seven major themes, namely access, assurances, positivity, openness, empathy, purpose, and diversity climate.

4. Findings

This study aimed to examine the relational maintenance strategies employed by organizations to maintain relationships with employees over remote/hybrid work in a crisis. The seven main themes generated from in-depth elite interviews with heads of communication and human resource managers from companies on various best employer lists clustered into two sets of strategies. The first set consisted of strategies that are widely accepted in current relationship management theorizing in public relations, specifically access, assurances, positivity, and openness (Hon & Grunig, 1999). The second set included three emergent strategies, namely, empathy, purpose, and diversity climate. See Table 1 for a summary of the findings. Together, these strategies reflected the lived experiences of employers as they grappled with maintaining relationships with employees remotely while navigating uncertain and ambiguous environments. The following paragraphs elaborate on these themes.

4.1. Access

One of the major relational strategies employed by companies on best employer lists was to intensify access to senior management. According to Hon & Grunig (1999), access refers to members of publics or opinion leaders providing access to public relations practitioners and vice versa, with public relations representatives or senior managers providing representatives of publics similar access to organizational

decision-making processes. Some of the sub-themes related to the overarching theme of access, included constructs such as listening, two-way communication, communication frequency, channels, and sources.

Participants shared how important it was to continue to ensure access to the senior management and leadership team when employees were abruptly thrust into remote work, disrupting regular modes of access. Organizational listening, enacted through policies, systems, structures, resources, and a range of processes, technologies, and specialist skills that enable and facilitate delegated, mediated, large-scale listening came to the fore, becoming the primary driver of access. Participating organizations shared that listening through surveys, polling software, townhalls, Q&A sessions, and conversations with managers enabled them to “get some perspective to understand what’s going on” (P3), and “to hear what employees are saying, to understand what they need, understand what we can give to them” (P8).

Related to the notion of organizational listening, most participants shared that during the pandemic, communication direction rapidly transformed from one-way to **two-way communication**. For example, P6 shared:

I would say internal comms was mainly a one-way communication. The leader or the exec or the CEO would send an email, and that’s it. They say what they want to say. People listen, they might comment, but it was not really a two-way conversation. However, all this changed.

Although majority of participants stressed the importance of two-way communication, interestingly P7, a head of employee relations, opined that even one-way communication shows respect to employees. The participant noted spending time communicating signals “you matter to me ... That’s why I’m spending time to tell you ... I want to do it as a matter of respect.”

In addition to organizational listening and two-way communication, another important sub-theme of access was **communication frequency**. Participants shared that in the initial months of the pandemic the communication frequency was “intense” (P1). Organizations had daily, weekly, and monthly communication through emails, townhalls, calls etc. However, as the pandemic dragged along, organizations faced the challenge of striking the right balance, with employers not wanting to “spam our employees” (P10), to “managing the noise, and not over communicating to our people” (P9). P8 articulated this dilemma well:

We’d have a pretty regular town hall ... we’d have probably once a month. And I think there was discussion, in terms of how often we would make them. We wanted to keep employees informed, but we didn’t want to deluge them with too much information. Work needed

Table 1
Summary of EOR maintenance strategies during the pandemic.

Extant Strategies	Emergent Strategies
☐ Access to organizational decision makers	☐ Empathy demonstrating organization’s concern for employee publics
☐ Assurances that employee concerns are legitimate	☐ Purpose statements on environmental, economic, or sociopolitical issues
☐ Positivity indicating efforts to make the relationship more enjoyable	☐ Diversity climate that fosters openness to diversity, equity, and inclusion
☐ Openness of thoughts and feelings	

to be done. People needed to get on with their jobs. And they're not going to be able to do that if they're constantly in meetings with management.

Participants used a plethora of mostly digital **communication channels** to provide access, including formal channels such as emails, polling software, live interactive data over Zoom and MS Teams, online town halls, and videos. Participants noted that there was a shift to digital visual communication to enhance affective employee engagement, illustrated very well by P10:

The one thing I would say that really changed during COVID is there was a lot more video interactions. So instead of writing, having a piece written and submitted to employees ... for example, a letter from our CEO or managing director ... what changed is those all transformed into videos because we wanted them to see - they had to see the emotions, they have to feel that this person cares about the employees. Interactions were more virtual, and more video based.

Access was provided by diverse **communication sources**, including senior leadership, corporate/internal communication teams, human resources leaders, and managers. Senior leadership was often the main face of internal communication, especially during the initial phases of the crisis, as P1 shared, "But I think what was very important for us to show leadership. So we think authenticity was really important. So [name of CEO], our CEO ... he was leading this, right? So he was in front of our employees."

However, participants also noted the need to diversify voices, including IT, HR, and marketing. "During your crisis, I think it's also good kind of not to give only one power of authority. We start leveraging the voice of HR, managers..." (P12) "And this was not just the communications department working silently. It was combined effort with IT, HR, marketing, comms, everybody had to kind of join hands together with the leadership team (P13).

4.2. Assurances

Defined as "attempts by parties in the relationship to assure the other parties that they and their concerns are legitimate" (Hon & Grunig, 1999), this second theme stood out prominently for most participants. Given the anxieties and uncertainties around an emerging global health crisis, a large portion of what participants shared could be grouped under this theme of offering assurances to employees. Organizations assured their employees that their concerns were real and legitimate and shared what the organization was doing to demonstrate their commitment to employees. Almost all participants spoke about addressing issues of employees' physical safety and security; psychological safety that revolved around concerns about job losses and eventually issues around mental health; and the inordinate emphases placed on taking care of employees and on managing blurring boundaries between home and work.

Most organizations spoke about assuring employees about physical safety and security, as employees turned inwards to organizations who "got your back" (P12). To these companies, "The safety of employees always came first. [During] pandemics ... you don't look at revenue, you don't look financials, you don't look at anything else anymore" (P10). For instance, P11 shared that the communication "started focusing on how the workplace is safe and all measures are being taken to ensure that you are being protected. Your health is of importance ... So that has given a lot of confidence."

Once the initial physical safety and security concerns were addressed and the pandemic dragged on, organizations turned to assuring employees of psychological safety – concerns that mostly revolved around worries about job losses and mental health. For instance, P2 shared, "[Name of company] is a great company where you don't worry about your jobs. Your jobs would be safe. You're not going to get fired like other retail companies in the country". P9, head of communications at a

global consulting company, exemplified this view:

The biggest kind of concern at that point was ... Am I losing my job or not? And that was the first message that we put out ... The chairman said it clearly, "No one is getting fired based on the pandemic, and full stop."

As employees continued to be isolated from colleagues, "the white elephant in the room" (P2) became mental health, which employers had to acknowledge as a legitimate concern that needed to be addressed through policies and initiatives such as adding mental health to insurance packages, running employee well-being programs, and instituting campaigns on helping employees manage increasingly vanishing boundaries between home and work. As P2 elaborated:

Nobody really wants to discuss about it. Everybody knows in a casual setting, perhaps, that it's being brought up. It's just that on the later part – I'd say 2021 – that we tried to discuss it. We actually had to ask our insurance company to include mental health or at least subsidize the treatment on employees who would like to seek psychiatric help with their issues right after part of the pandemic.

Most importantly, organizations recognized that employee mindsets conditioned to organizational expectations of long hours at work was an issue that needed to be addressed. Consequently, organizations ran campaigns that assured employees it was all right to switch off to manage well-being. For instance, P12 shared an example of a campaign that attempted to reassure employees that it is okay to miss out:

... the problem that we had in the beginning is also there was a fear of missing out. And, I mean, "I have to be in every meeting. I have to be in on every email. I have to be in every call. I have to be in every planning." And then you saw people who have more time because they don't have family at home, are being able to work 12, 13, 14 h a day, while the ones with family are struggling. And one of the messaging we start changing is the fear from missing out, to move to the joy of missing out. It's okay not to be there.

Blurring boundaries between home and work while working remotely became another issue and participants shared that they created programs that focused on respecting boundaries of people. As P4 explained:

So we've told our employees, please block your time when you have something critical, you're working on a project, you're completing a course, you are wanting to do something that's different, you don't want to be disturbed, just block your calendar.

Companies even ran formal campaigns on "saying no ... say no to meetings. Say no to your manager. Say no to requests that you don't think [are] impactful. Say no to calls in the evening. I don't need all of these five people in these meetings" (P12). In addition, companies generated "Work from Home pledges" (P6), where employees generated pledges for themselves such as, "I pledged to be family sensitive. I pledged to support flexibility for personal needs. I pledged to support not camera-ready times."

4.3. Positivity

Defined as "anything the organization or public does to make the relationship more enjoyable for the parties involved" (Hon & Grunig, 1999), participating organizations shared how they were focused not only on creating safe, caring, and pleasant workplaces to improve relationships with employees, but actively worked to inject optimism into the work environment. The underlying premise of leveraging positivity was to create a safe, caring, and pleasant workplace, where organizations are "caring" and "respectful" (P7) and share a "sense of optimism" (P2) where "morales had to be kept high" (P13). As P3 shared:

And of course, it's really around how do we create an environment that's psychologically safe, where people can be really thriving, and how we can actually make a pleasant environment to work with ... how do we bond with each other, and how do we actually make a pleasant workplace?

Participants shared details of events they had organized to maintain social interaction, morale and positivity including trivias, online games, game shows, hobby challenges (P2, P3, P9) and TikTok challenges, as "the only thing that we could do in terms of entertaining aside from Netflix was watching TikTok videos" (P2). Companies organized coffee talks (P3), meditation and yoga classes (P13). As P10 explained, these programs helped to build a sense of togetherness among employees:

There were many group discussions on ... many topics which people might have raised on a certain platform that they feel that they're struggling with. And those really help because you would find that many people from the same area working with you have similar problems. You're not alone. You don't feel that you are left alone working digitally from a laptop for a certain company. You're actually part of the team. You are struggling together.

Further, companies organized events to celebrate important personal and professional milestones. For instance, P5 shared a campaign called, "Moments that Matter", where they celebrated birthdays, new babies, promotions, or anniversaries, as they were seen to be critical to building relationships with employees. Similarly, P13 shared another campaign called "Everyday Heroes", where "individual cases of bravery of people who were showing up for work consistently for 60 days, 90 days, and they are frontline workers, going through the harshest of conditions to save patients, and some phenomenal cases that have been done." Interestingly, P7 shared an example of a campaign built around gratitude, employees thanking each other for being there for each other:

So let's be caring. Let's be respectful ... let's be the energy of your colleagues. So we made a campaign that goes, let's be the energy for each other ... So people start thanking people, thank you for being my energy during the pandemic when this and this happened, and I was super low, and then you were there to take care of me ... So internally, funny enough, this moment of thanking people ... helped us to transition to become a better company.

4.4. Openness

Another theme that stood out prominently was the extent of honest, open communication organizations engaged in to maintain relationships with employees over remote work during the pandemic. Openness, described as "openness of thoughts and feelings among parties involved" (Hon & Grunig, 1999) was manifested in multiple ways. First, participants acknowledged the uncertainties surrounding the unfolding situation and was open and honest about conceding the "firefighting" nature of the situation where "everyone was in the dark" (P2), where if "we don't know, we don't know" (P3), where "everyone is learning, everyone is experimenting" and about "showing your people vulnerability as well" (P5). However, everyone was in the process of learning together, where "we're going to fail fast, and then we're going to learn from that" (P5). P5's words illustrated these sentiments well:

I think one thing the pandemic has shown me personally is that as a leader, you cannot be the know-it-all. You should be the learn-it-all ... And it's about showing your people vulnerability as well. If you do not have an answer, no one's saying that you should have all the answers. It's letting people know, "I'm learning as well. I'm learning from other people. I'm learning from other leaders. And let's experiment together. And if it works, great. If it's not, we fail fast."

Openness also indicated the need for clear and transparent communication, "to be honest with your employees" (P10). "Crystal transparent

or extremely transparent message that goes out to every single person highlighting every single thing that will bring trust to them" and "bring confidence that the firm is literally beside them" (P9) was important to most participants. For instance, referring to internal communication on employee satisfaction surveys, P11 shared:

And then this transparency around results and saying, "We scored really well in this, but you know what? We're still not where we want to be in this area." And it's not being apologetic for that. In some ways, it's just kind of being able to confront that, and all of us going, "You know what? We've got some work to do around that," and then kind of working together to try and, what can the company do to address that?

However, a few participants also qualified open and honest communication with the need to manage the "panic versus protection" dilemma (P3). As P3 explained this further:

Because there was a need to be nimble, but also very careful about how we actually communicate around those things because one, you have to balance not to panic the employees – that's very important – yet protecting the employee in the same time.

4.5. Empathy

Although not a part of the original Hon and Grunig's (1999) theorizing of relational maintenance strategies, empathy was foregrounded by the participants as a major relational maintenance strategy during the pandemic. Empathy "stems from another's emotional state or condition and is congruent with the other's emotional state or condition" (Eisenberg, Shea, Carlo, & Knight, 2014, p. 65). When individuals personally or vicariously experience the emotions of others, they respond with affective or emotional empathy (Tangney, Stuewig, & Mashek, 2007). When individuals assume the perspective of others to understand their emotional experiences, they respond with cognitive empathy (Eisenberg et al., 2014). Empathy is seen as an other-oriented emotional process (Noddings, 2013) or self-transcendent value that stimulates prosocial action tendencies (Tangney et al., 2007).

Participants shared that the exigencies of the pandemic that exposed the vulnerabilities of employees' lives demanded that organizations respond empathically, with "emotional intelligence" (P1) to transform into people-centric organizations. For instance, P6 shared:

I don't think I've seen anyone who has not shown his other side or his emotions during the pandemic. It exposed everyone. And because it's like we were all in this together, it's not like you're passing through it and I'm not feeling it, right. I've had my own piece of it. I've had families. I've had friends who actually died, who actually went through this. So you feel it. There's this emotional connection that became very strong that you feel it.

Empathy was a core value especially for leaders and managers. Participants spoke about leaders who led versus focused on tasks, those who inspire, empower, and are full of optimism (P1, P2, P5, P6). Besides empathetic communication role modeled by senior management and organizational leaders, managers were seen as pivotal to managing relationships with employees. "They were the sponge, taking the pressure from the employees and the anxiety, but as a manager, you have to show your strength by not just channelling fears to the leadership team" (P12). Managers were seen as role models and coaches (P12) on managing with empathy. As P11 shared, "So I think managers having this responsibility to really kind of role model the behaviour."

4.6. Purpose

Organizational purpose has become a buzzword in organizations and is defined as "why you exist: and the positive impact in people's lives and the world they live in" (Kantar Consulting, 2018, p. 12). Purpose

represents the heart of the business model and is the reason for being. Although related constructs of corporate social advocacy (Browning et al., 2020) and corporate social responsibility (Dhanesh, 2014) have been advanced as relational cultivation strategies for employees, participants in this study unequivocally foregrounded the importance of crafting and communicating a clear organizational purpose that can bind employees together with a sense of shared purpose. For instance, P8 defined purpose and its role in engendering employee commitment during remote work:

A company's purpose is, obviously, to - the simplest format, to make money and to return value to shareholders, but every company should be doing this. So what is your purpose beyond that? For example, at [name of company] it was all about sustainability. It was all about making the world a greener, better place, improving operations, reducing energy, reducing water, reducing carbon emissions ... So with a purpose you're bringing your employees together, you're giving them something to aim at and aim towards.

Participants shared that employees often want "clear stands from the company" (P1) on social and even political issues, which will increase the bonding. Yet another participant (P3) from a company that was related to manufacturing masks shared how articulating their organizational purpose in cogent terms helped them to feel like superheroes:

... we had a responsibility towards the world. Although we were not really producing the mask, but we did feel like we were part of that company that was mandated to actually kind of be a superhero ... We felt like we were driving for a purpose, and we were part of that purpose to kind of help the world getting better.

P7 shared a poignant story about the transformation at a utility company from a company with no clearly articulated purpose to one that marshalled its troops to focus on one clearly articulated purpose, which helped in fostering relationships with employees:

There was a big problem with [name of company], which was [name of company] was a company with no purpose. [Name] was a company that had the big name ... but people used to go to work because of the product, because of the quality, and because of the name, but they didn't have a purpose. So when you want to attract new generations and when you want to attract people outside [name of country], you need a purpose-led organization, and that was completely missing. And the pandemic reminded us of the purpose for [name of company], that was to keep the lights on ... And that brought people the purpose on why we are here. So we are here to bring energy to the whole planet because if we are not here, hospitals will not work, people will not be able to help each other, no one can manage, no one ... It helped us a lot to create sense of belonging and sense of purpose on what we were doing and a little bit of pride.

Organizational purpose can help to foster stronger relationships with employees through alignment between organizational and individual employee purpose. For instance, P9 shared, "... we always refer to ourselves as a purpose-driven organization. And we do work a lot on that ... We have multiple assertions on personal purpose, aligning personal purpose to the organizational purpose."

4.7. Diversity climate

Finally, one of the strongest emergent themes from the study was the need to nurture a positive diversity climate to be able to manage relationships with employees in future ways of working. Diversity climate refers to the extent to which an organization is open to maintaining an inclusive workplace (Cox, 2001) and is defined as the "degree to which a firm advocates fair human resource policies and socially integrates underrepresented employees" (McKay, Avery, & Morris, 2008, p. 350). Overall, diversity climate has been found to positively contribute to work outcomes, such as job satisfaction, sense of inclusion, and work

group identification.

When asked about managing relationships with employees going forward, most participants shared that they intend to create inclusive workspaces that consider employee diversity in terms of gender, life-style, age, family roles etc. It was about creating structures and mindsets for inclusive workspaces where employees are empowered to choose their preferred modes of working depending on their personal life needs. Participants foregrounded the need for employee empowerment to enable employees to choose their preferred modes of working, "to meet people where they are" (P11), as "one policy is not going to respond to all the needs" (P5).

Participants also noted that future workplaces need to cater for generational diversity. For instance, P4 shared that even before the pandemic as they were gearing to hire millennials and Gen Zs, they had started initiatives such as "Dress Your Way" where employees could dress in anything that is comfortable and acceptable in local society if they are not visiting customers. After the pandemic hit, the company extended this program to include "Work Your Way", which reflected how employees want to work. Similarly, participants also acknowledged diversity among employees in terms of family roles and responsibilities. For instance, P1 shared:

This is a very personal thing, this whole pandemic. And everybody sees it differently. Everybody has a different situation at home. Sometimes a spouse works, sometimes doesn't work. Sometimes you live with your family together. So the problems are very different. So you just need to really live your values, what you stand for, and how you want to support your employees, and to which level you want to support them.

To summarize, this study generated seven major themes relating to employee relational maintenance strategies during remote work in a crisis. The themes consisted of strategies that are discussed in current relationship management theorizing in public relations, specifically access, assurances, positivity, and openness (Hon & Grunig, 1999) as well as emergent strategies of empathy, purpose, and diversity climate. The discussion section will now elaborate on the findings in the context of extant literature on maintenance strategies in organization-employee-relationships.

5. Discussion and conclusions

This study examined the relational maintenance strategies employed by organizations to maintain relationships with employees over remote/hybrid work in a crisis and identified seven major strategies. The results demonstrate that when organizations experience crises, they resort to established relational maintenance strategies such as access, assurances, positivity, and openness. This result echoes the findings of previous studies (Grunig & Huang, 2000; Hon & Grunig, 1999) that EORs are effectively maintained through initiating collaborative actions that result in the co-creation of solutions and meaningful dialogic interactions. The four established maintenance strategies will be discussed next, followed by the three emergent strategies.

Access to organizational decisionmakers was provided to employees through numerous organizational listening tactics, pivoting from one-way to two-way communication, increasing communication frequency especially at the onset of the pandemic, utilizing digital communication channels, and making diverse communication sources available to employees. Previous scholars (Dhanesh & Duthler, 2021; Heide & Simonsson, 2020) noted that internal crisis communication content and two-way communication predicted employee engagement and when diverse channels and discussion platforms were leveraged, it enhanced the quality of EORs as employee uncertainty was reduced. Our findings suggest that meaningful dialogic interactions can be achieved through authentic messaging, digital interactive visual communication, and the diversification of communication sources through interdepartmental collaboration (HR, PR, IT etc.).

Second, assurances were given to employees through communicative actions to demonstrate organizations' commitment to maintaining and building EORs. To achieve this, campaigns and programs were launched focusing on employees' physical safety, mental health, and well-being as well as practical advice on how to manage the blurring of boundaries between work/home. This demonstrated organizational attentiveness and responsibility (Tronto, 1993), that is, being attuned to the changing informational and psychological needs of employees during the constantly evolving health crisis. The conscious recognition of work-life tensions, engaging in conversations with employees about the stressors, and the active addressal thereof further highlighted the organizational justice and fairness dimensions of organizations' internal relationship management strategies (Lee, 2021). These tactics promoted moral relationships between relational parties who experienced varying forms of vulnerability during the pandemic (Engster, 2020). Additionally, organizations were flexible in supporting employees' needs and organizational cultures evolved through the deliberate cultivation of psychologically safe spaces. This echoes findings that the quality of EORs is enhanced through supportive organizational cultures where tangible and intangible support is provided to employees (Men & Jiang, 2016).

In terms of positivity, this study found that organizations managed EORs through embedding elements of emotional culture in the workplace (Men & Robinson, 2018). This included expressing gratitude, acknowledging meritorious employees along with celebrating joyful moments such as professional milestones (Dirani et al. 2020). Values associated with the care ethics framework such as benevolence, respect as well as security and protection (Noddings, 2013) were emphasized in organizations' communication campaigns and virtual programs. EORs were also managed through participatory activities that not only promoted positivity but also contributed to high levels of social bonding (Grunig et al., 2002). In remote/hybrid contexts it is crucial to manage EORs by keeping employees engaged and connected to the organization. Through launching programs and communications focused on relational principles (i.e., esteeming employees, listening to their concerns, responding, and promoting mutual understanding), the social exchange between employees and organizations was enhanced and stimulated bondedness (Einwiller et al., 2021). These tactics follow a care ethics approach where the reciprocal relationship between the one-caring (i.e., organizations) and the cared-for (i.e., employees) is developed and cultivated to "maintain relations of care and trust" (Noddings, 2015, p. 74).

Related to championing positivity and emotional work cultures, organizations engaged in open communication to maintain EORs. Transparent internal communication, focused on honest disclosures about the evolving nature of the pandemic, was utilized to reduce employees' uncertainty and feelings of ambiguity (Li et al., 2021). Informational communication sources (i.e., health and safety updates, social distancing guidelines, content on IT-related issues etc.) were key in assisting employees manage their day-to-day tasks while working in remote/hybrid contexts. Participants in this study also equated clear, transparent communication to inspiring confidence and trust in employees. By acting swiftly and addressing employees' informational needs through various forms of access, organizations fulfilled the competence dimension of care ethics. Organizations provided good care by means of adequate information resources thus fulfilling the need for care (Tronto, 1993). These results reinforce findings of previous studies that showed disseminating transparent, open, and information-rich communication assisted employees in managing additional job-related demands placed on them during remote work in a crisis (Dhanesh & Duthler, 2021; Einwiller et al., 2021).

In addition to the aforementioned antecedents of EORs, three new antecedents of EORs, namely empathy, purpose, and diversity climate were identified. They are discussed next.

Previous studies (Coombs, 2007; Coombs, 2015) have shown organizational empathy plays a role in times of crisis as it maintains OPRs

(Kent & Taylor, 2002). More recently, scholars found that empathetic crisis communication humanized organizations as ethical entities, framed leader-spokespersons as caring, and emphasized the organization's concern for the well-being of publics (Schoofs et al., 2022). In line with these findings, our study shows empathy was the genesis for changing organizational identities from industrial-centric to people-centric, and reframing task-oriented leaders as caring and empathetic. Participants stressed that people-centric organizations will be an enduring construct embedded in new ways of working philosophies as organizations adopt hybrid/remote work models. Our findings also indicate that informal, interactive audiovisual leadership communication became an emotional resource used to maintain EORs. Leadership communication became more relational as storytelling and personal anecdotes were frequently included in internal communications, and the tone changed from task-oriented to optimistic and inspirational. Managerial interactions with employees followed a humanistic approach (Dong & Morehouse, 2022) and were characterized by actions that cultivated empathy such as role-modelling vulnerability and acting as work-life balance coaches. By focusing on employees' physical and mental well-being, listening to, and identifying areas that cause anxiety in employees, managers were able to cultivate safe, secure emotional work cultures. Empathy ties in with care ethics literature wherein relational parties "feel something" toward each other (Noddings, 2015, p. 75), and the carer attentively responds to the needs of the cared-for, thus, demonstrating empathy. Theoretically, this study regards empathy as a proximal antecedent because the implementation of empathetic communication and making empathetic work-related decisions (e.g., offering additional support structures, flexible work options to manage one's physical or mental health etc.) appeared to nurture EORs.

Remote/hybrid work contexts often result in feelings of disengagement, loneliness, and loss of social connection (Kniffin et al., 2020). To negate and address these negative emotions, organizations in our study embarked on a journey to rearticulate a shared organizational purpose. This was, in part, ignited by employees' advocacy behaviors and their expectations that their organization should demonstrate social responsibility. Crafting a reimagined purpose and voicing stands on environmental, economic, or sociopolitical issues (i.e., engaging in explicit corporate advocacy communication behaviors) were found to increase the social cohesiveness of employees and assisted organizations in managing EORs in remote/hybrid work contexts. This is in line with previous studies that found corporate advocacy strengthened OPRs and increased publics' support for organizations (Browning et al., 2020). From a care ethics standpoint, striving for "inclusion" by emphasizing a shared organizational purpose, signals organizations' on-going commitment to having sustained and caring relationships with relational parties (Noddings, 2013, p. 62). This action is also linked to the ethical dimension of attentiveness as organizations were observant of employees' need to have a unifying goal (Tronto, 1993). Our study classifies purpose as a distal antecedent because the reimagining of organizational purpose is theorized to be of a more stable and enduring nature. However, this means that organizations that rediscovered or reformulated their organizational purpose during the COVID-19 pandemic will have to invest in continued, long-term communication campaigns to influence employees' perceptions of the organization as an entity with a newly defined purpose.

Lastly, organizations in our study cultivated robust diversity climates to manage EORs. Diversity climate is closely aligned to the construct of organizational justice that predicts the quality of EORs (Lee, 2021). We theorize diversity climate as a proximal antecedent since it could have an immediate impact on EORs and influence employees' perceptions of OPRs. Diversity climate is a less stable construct and organizations have the freedom to implement it in various ways. For example, organizations have carte blanche to design inclusive workplaces and workplace policies based on principles of fairness, justice, and equality that suit their unique business context and operational needs. Organizations in our study experimented with various programs to advance inclusion as well

as drive awareness of diversity issues. These programs were enacted as means of nurturing EORs through an other-oriented framework (Noddings, 2013). Similarly, Dong and Morehouse (2022) include recognition of publics' diversity in terms of demographics, opinions, and their unique vulnerabilities in their care-based relationship cultivation model. They note that "care means recognizing and respecting diverse publics and their distinct vulnerabilities" (Dong & Morehouse, 2022, p. 189). Again, this points to the first and third ethical dimensions of care ethics, namely being attentive to relational parties' needs and responding in a competent manner (Tronto, 1993). In our study, organizations actively addressed the need to have equitable workplaces by exploring employee perceptions through two-way communication and listening. These tactics enabled employees to co-create work arrangements based on their unique personal life requirements.

Conversely, if organizations do not foster open, inclusive, and equitable diversity climates wherein divergent generational, lifestyle, family role, and personal life needs are taken into consideration, it will have negative consequences for EORs. Establishing and maintaining trusting relationships with employees is important in both physical workplaces and when work moves online and back as during the COVID-19 pandemic. Leading organizations managed relationships with employees over remote/hybrid work through establishing diversity climates and empowering employees to choose and enact their preferred modes of working. These actions are seen as essential support mechanisms provided to employees in an effort to strengthen EORs. Our study showed creating positive diversity climates including diversity of work arrangements and offering organization-specific diversity training programs improved employees' experiences at work.

5.1. Theoretical and practical implications

First, this study contributes to the body of knowledge on relationship management and strategic internal crisis communication by examining the relational maintenance strategies utilized by top employers to manage EORs during remote/hybrid work in the COVID-19 pandemic. Building on established relationship management theory (e.g., Grunig, 1993; Grunig & Huang, 2000; Hon & Grunig, 1999; Ledingham & Bruning, 2000), and a care ethics framework (Dong & Morehouse, 2022; Noddings, 2013, 2015; Tronto, 1993), the current study advances the understanding of managing OPRs and especially EORs during remote/hybrid work contexts during a crisis. Most importantly, it has not only provided empirical evidence for a set of established relational maintenance strategies that were gainfully employed in the turbulent contexts of the crisis, but also offered evidence for three new strategies. The findings of this study thus help to extend relationship management theorizing to new contexts of remote work.

Our study extends Dong and Morehouse's (2022) care-based relationship cultivation model, that proposes both traditional and new care-based strategies to manage government-public relationships, to the context of EORs. Following a similar care ethics framework (Noddings, 2013; 2015; Tronto, 1993), our study identified one overlapping strategy (empathy) as well as two additional care-based strategies (purpose and diversity climate) used in the ethical building of EORs. These strategies emphasize relational aspects such as care, well-being, and the protection of vulnerability, and serve as an alternative orientation to manage EORs where clear power imbalances exist.

Second, the study linked three of the four ethical dimensions of care ethics to relational maintenance strategies. Assurances were associated with attentiveness and responsibility; access with competence; and empathy, purpose as well as diversity climate with attentiveness. According to Bowen, Hung-Baesecke, and Chen (2016), although traditional relationship cultivation strategies aim to be ethical, theoretical conceptions do not overtly prioritize ethical values and principles. The identified care-based strategies explicate how the ethical dimensions of care ethics assisted organizations to manage complicated relational interactions with employees during an unprecedented global health crisis.

By being attentive (e.g., acknowledgment of legitimate concerns) to employees' varying care needs (e.g., physical and psychological), organizations assumed responsibility (e.g., active assumption of care needs), and provided competent responses (e.g., organizational listening, informational resources, wellness programs, etc.). This is indicative of organizations' care-based approach to where the primary focus was not on achieving organizational goals but on treating employees empathetically, fairly, and ethically.

Third, the study contributed to public relations theorizing by investigating the antecedents of EORs during remote work in a crisis. It reinforces existing findings that transparent internal crisis communication content and two-way communication predict employee engagement, build trust, and strengthen EORs during remote work (Dhanesh & Duthler, 2021; Li et al., 2021; Mazzei et al., 2012). Further, the study offered evidence that indicate the importance of using a wide array of communication resources during remote work in a crisis, especially access to organizational decisionmakers and digital communication channels. The study also showed relationship-oriented communication strategies such as empathetic leadership communication are increasingly used in turbulent contexts to maintain EORs (Schoofs et al., 2022). Finally, findings from our study revealed that pressures and tensions unleashed by remote work such as the blurring of boundaries between work/home need to be actively managed. Strategies drawn from social exchange theory (Blau, 1964) were primarily used to bolster EORs. This finding is supported by previous research that has found emotional resources (Coombs, 1999; Coombs & Holladay, 2008; Einwiller et al., 2021) and instructional information disseminated via diverse channels (Heide & Simonsson, 2020) are used in the maintenance of EORs during times of crisis.

Practically, the findings mean that organizations operating in remote/hybrid work contexts should explore advanced (digital) methods of listening to internal publics, leverage innovative virtual platforms to facilitate two-way communication, and continuously monitor communication frequency alongside diverse communication channels and sources. Relatedly, organizational awareness of employees' emotional and psychological states and agile communication approaches to meet the needs of employees during remote/hybrid work contexts during a crisis are important. Further interdisciplinary collaboration between HR and communications departments to create and communicate wellness programs to employees could be explored as one avenue to assure internal stakeholders of the organization's commitment to addressing their legitimate concerns.

6. Limitations and suggestions for further research

This qualitative study generated nuanced, in-depth insights into a complex situation, namely how organizations manage relationships with employees during remote/hybrid work during a crisis. Future research could expand on the insights through a quantitative study that examines the antecedents and outcomes of EORs. Further, the interviews were conducted with leaders from prominent multinational organizations identified as top workplaces. Subsequently, the findings do not reflect the views of organizations that do not feature on top employer lists, organizations that are regarded as average or below average workplaces on employee review sites such as Glassdoor, and smaller organizations. Future research could examine how a broader spectrum of companies managed EORs thus further enriching our understanding of employee relationship management.

Furthermore, the link between positivity and the effectiveness of employee engagement through communal activities (i.e., hobby sharing, entertainment challenges via social networking sites, and other shared interest groups) could be explored in greater detail. Relatedly, the need for honest, open, empathetic communication during crisis situations is crucial to fulfil employees' information seeking needs as well as protect employee well-being. Future studies could, therefore, investigate employees' perceptions of empathetic communication in crisis situations in

diverse contexts.

Finally, as organizations look ahead to remote, hybrid and virtual ways of working, closer study of tactics that organizations initiated to align employees' personal purpose to organizational purpose would be valuable for informing public relations theory and practice. The impact of organizational purpose as well as diversity climate on employees' perception of their relationship with the organization could also be explored.

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Data Availability

Data will be made available on request.

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